City of Cambridge

Community Development Department

Massachusetts Avenue & Cambridge Street Active Use Policy Order

Ordinance Committee Meeting

April 6, 2026

CITY OF CAMBRIDGE | CDD Community Development

POR 2025 #164

ORDERED: That the City Manager be and hereby is requested to direct the Community Development Department (CDD) and Law Department to **prepare a draft of a separate zoning petition to strengthen Active Use requirements on Cambridge Street and the Porter Square PUD subdistricts** for sites that redevelop as single parcels.

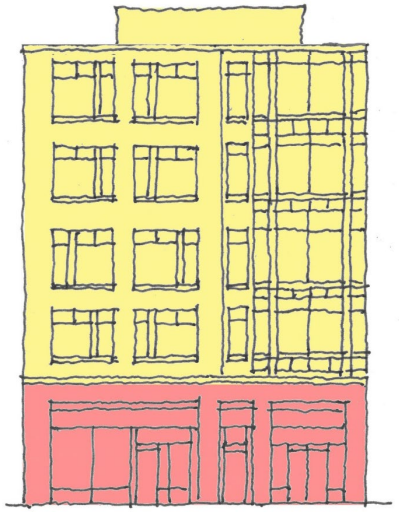
Ground Story Active Uses

Active Uses required for buildings above a certain height.

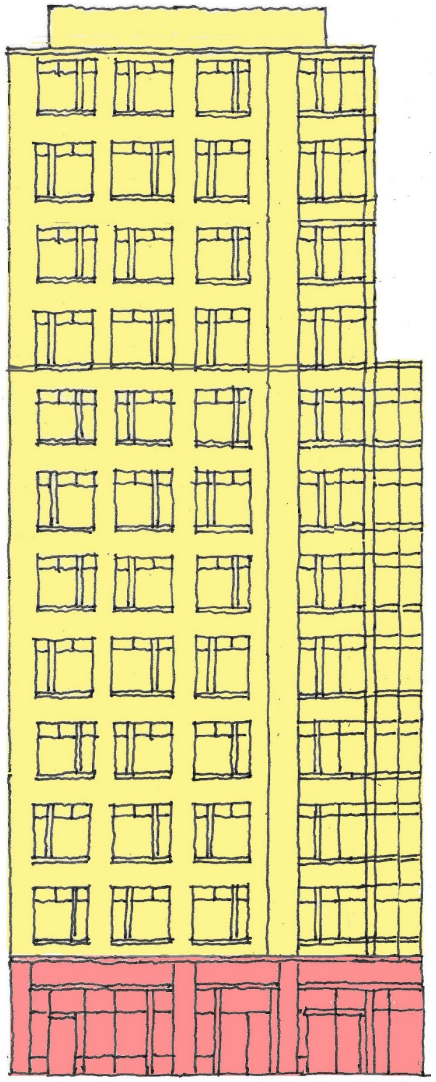
Current requirement for part of Mass Ave.



4 stories residential-only



5 stories residential with active ground story use



12 stories residential with active ground story use

Ground Story Active Uses

Active Uses include:

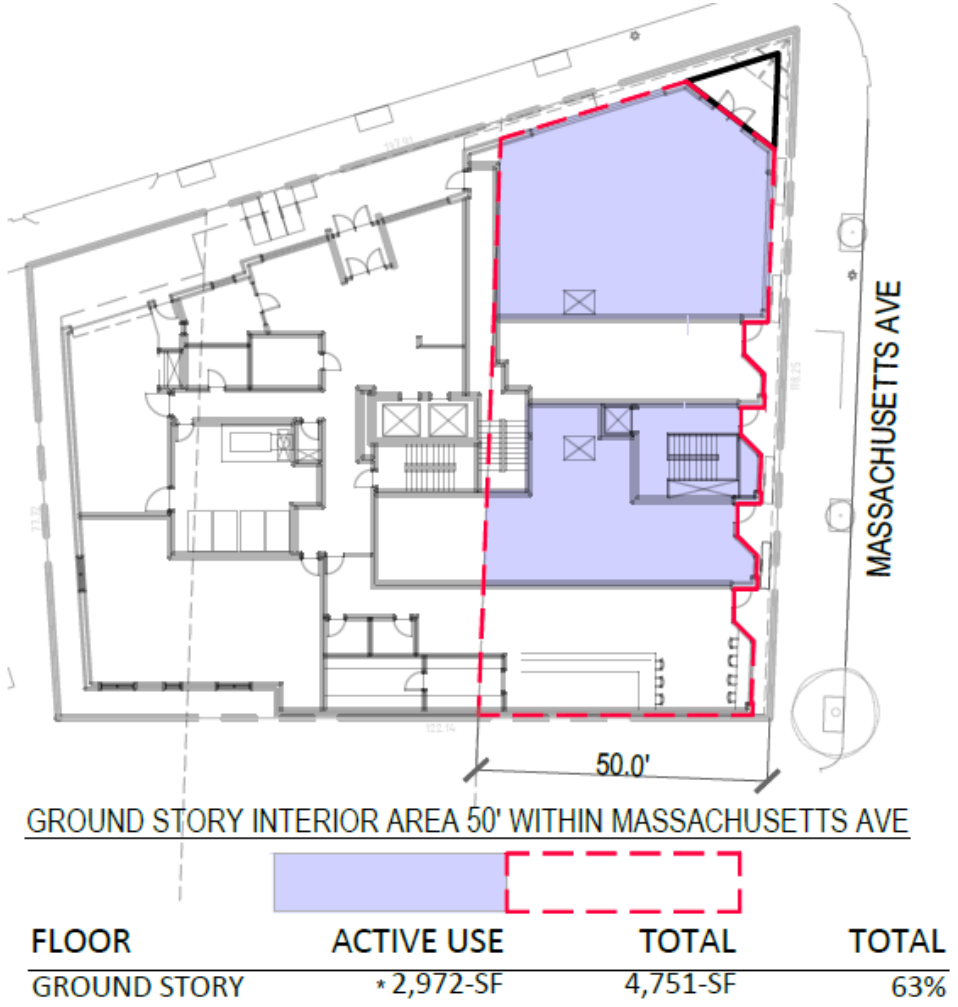
- **All institutional uses** including daycares, libraries, community centers.
- **Some office uses** like a dentist's office, accountant's office, or insurance agency. This does NOT include general offices, banks, or labs.
- **All retail and consumer services uses.**

Floor Area and Location Standards:

- 60% of interior floor area within 50' of the street







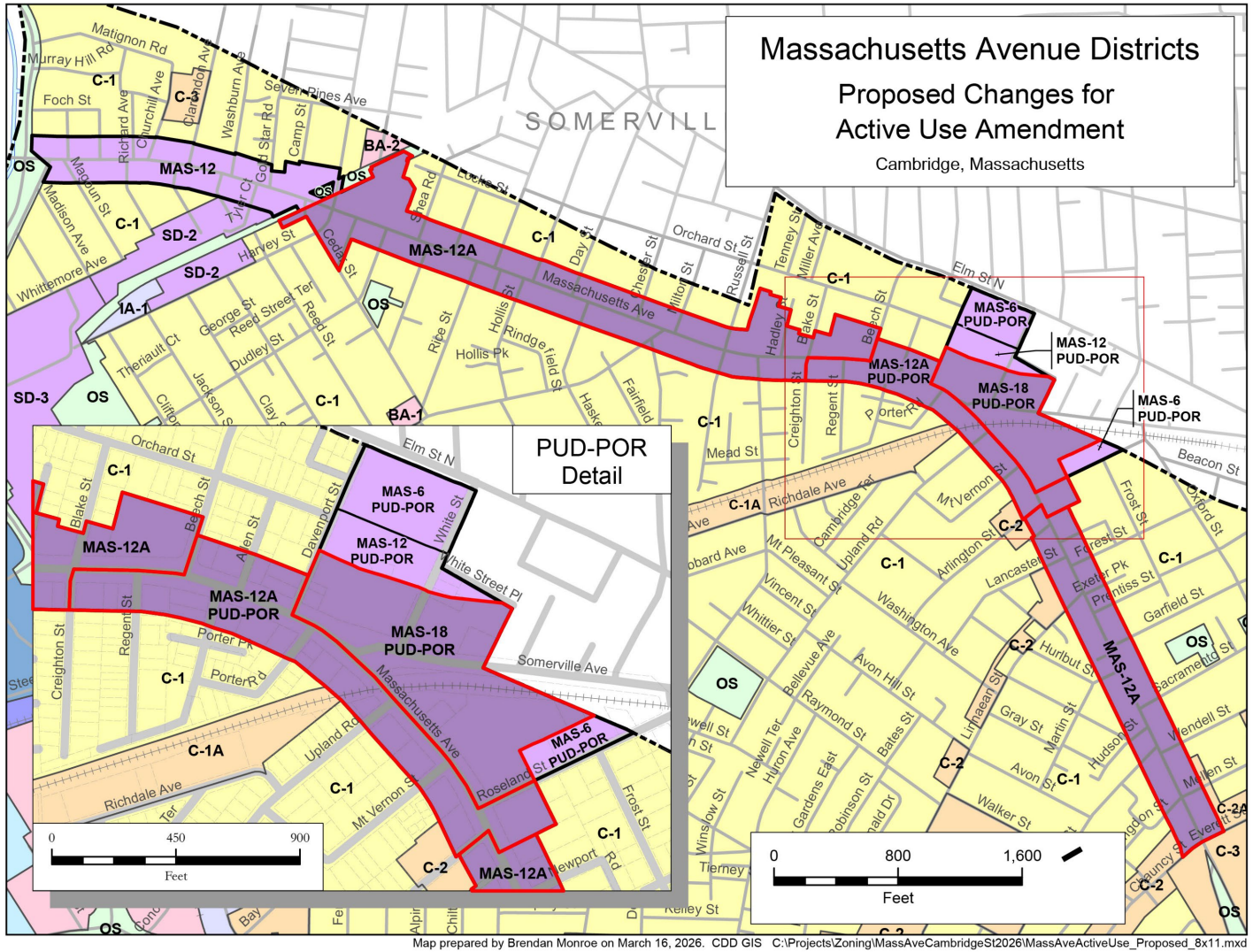
FLOOR	ACTIVE USE	TOTAL	TOTAL
GROUND STORY	* 2,972-SF	4,751-SF	63%

Mass Ave Recommendations

Require Active uses for buildings greater than 4 stories From Cambridge Common to Linear Park.

- Expand MAS-12A
- Active uses required for buildings greater than 4 stories in MAS-18

***General support for this approach at 3/11 Ordinance Committee Meeting**



Map prepared by Brendan Monroe on March 16, 2026. CDD GIS C:\Projects\Zoning\MassAveCambridgeSt2026\MassAveActiveUse_Proposed_8x11.mxd

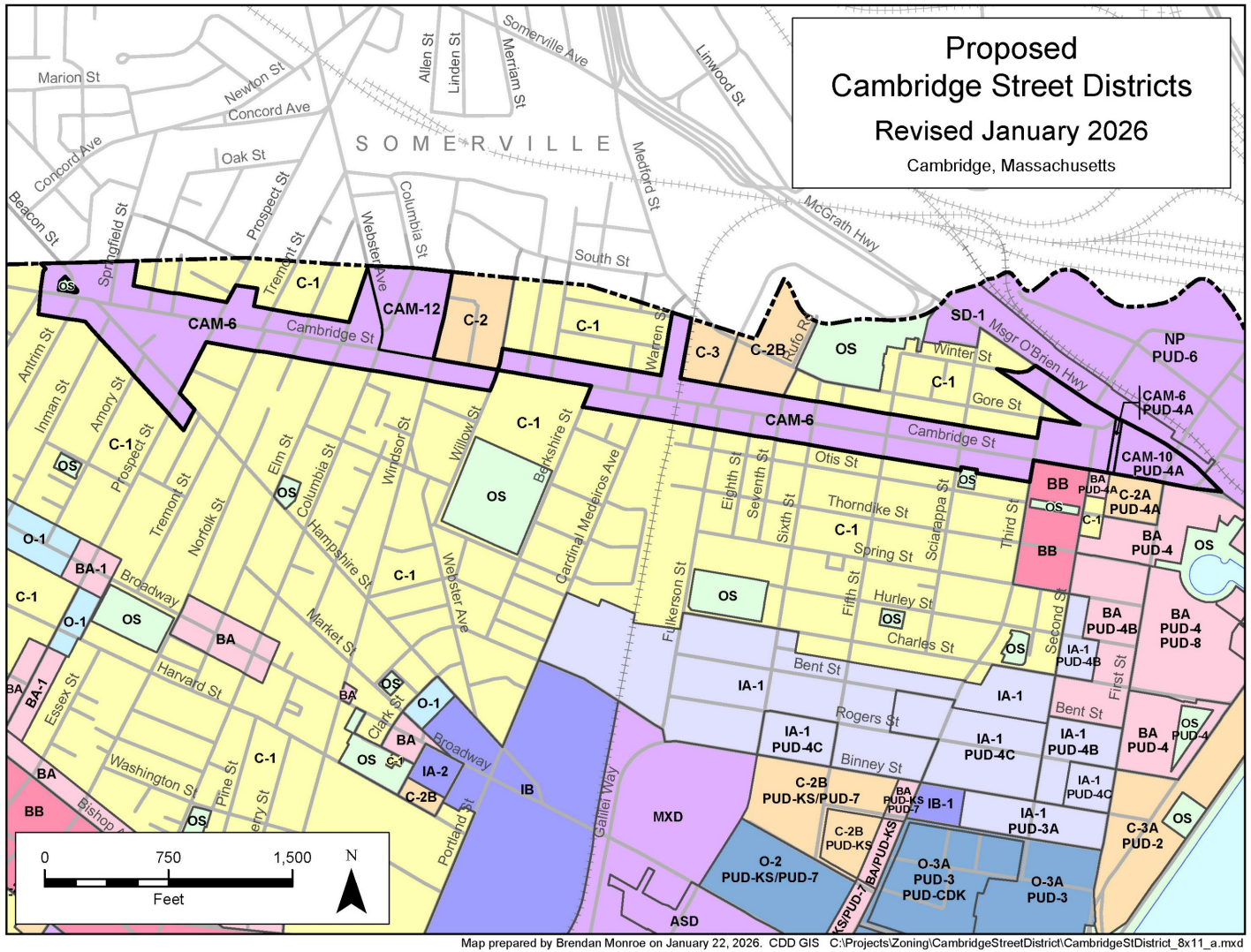
Existing Cambridge Street

Active Uses required for buildings above a certain height.

Cambridge St:

- Greater than 6 stories in Lechmere (CAM-10) and Webster/Windsor (CAM-12)

*Previous zoning (BA) allowed up to 6 stories with no active use requirement - same as new CAM-6 zoning.



Cambridge Street Recommendations

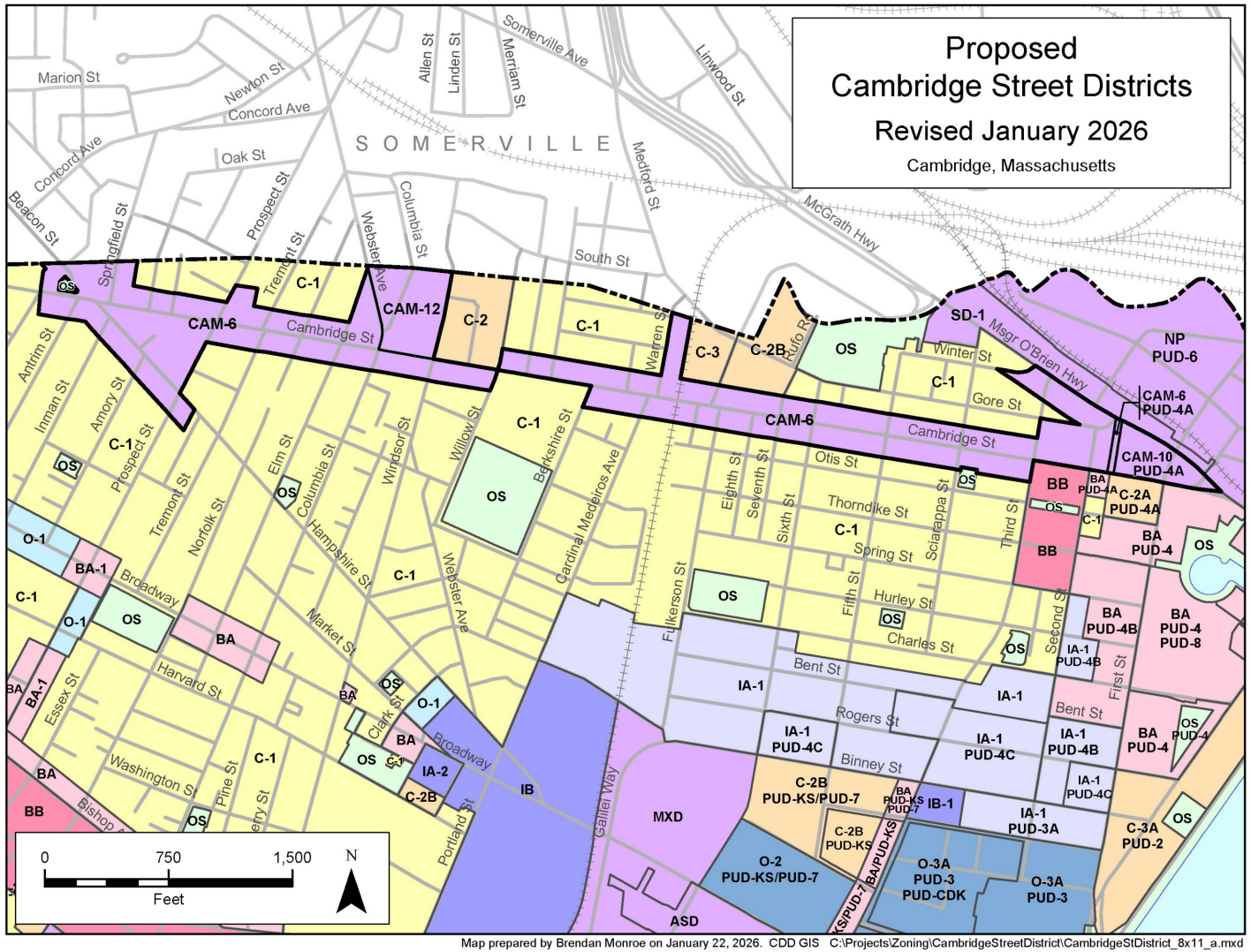
Option 1: Same as Mass Ave

- Active uses required above 4 stories in all CAM districts.

Option 2: Stronger

- Active uses required above 3 stories in all CAM districts.

Option 3…

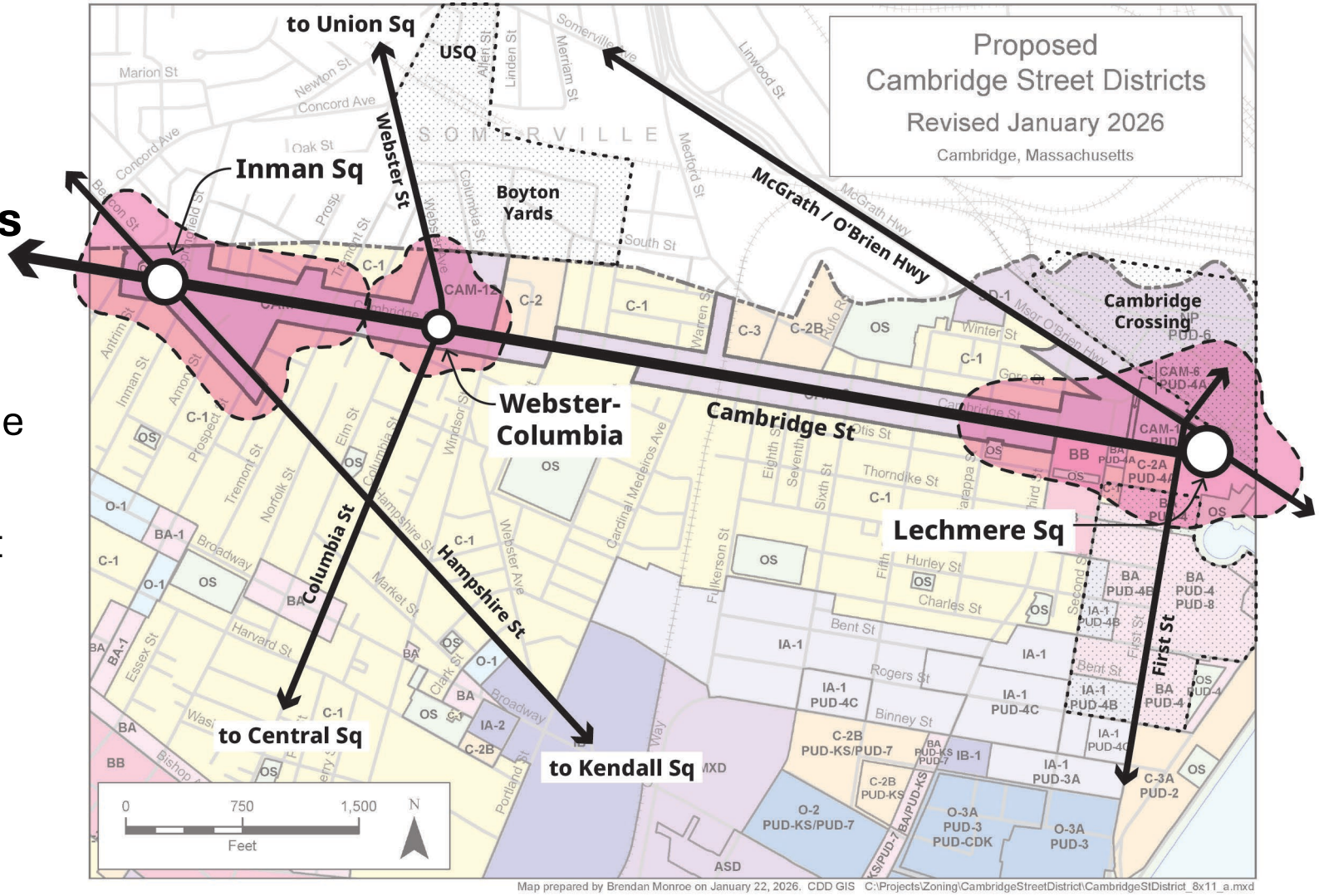


Cambridge Street Recommendations

Option 3: Active Use Nodes

Why these nodes?

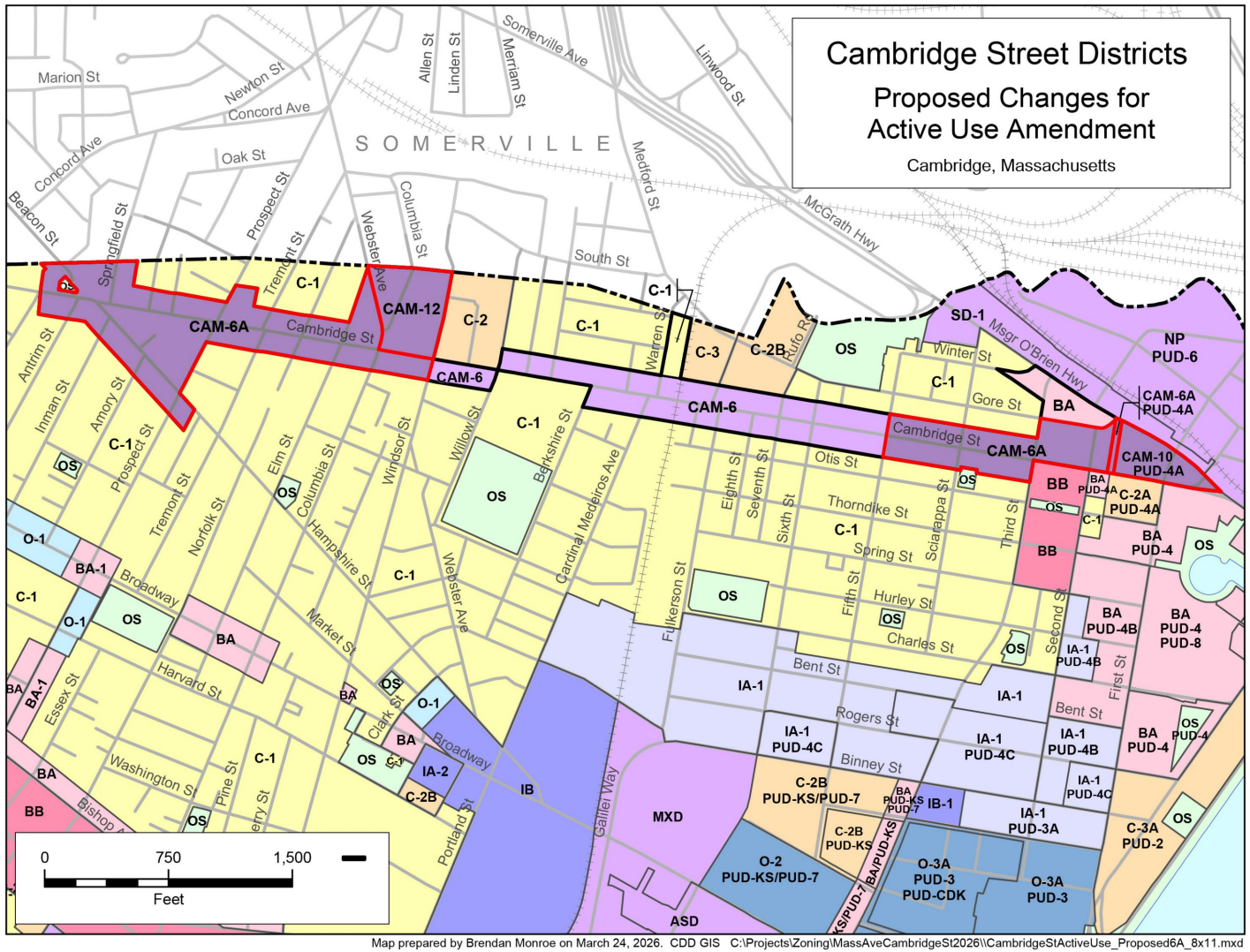
- **Existing** business activity is fairly consistent throughout the corridor.
- **Future** business development should be prioritized in areas closest to existing squares, transformative areas, and transportation infrastructure.



Cambridge Street Recommendations

Option 3: Active Use Nodes

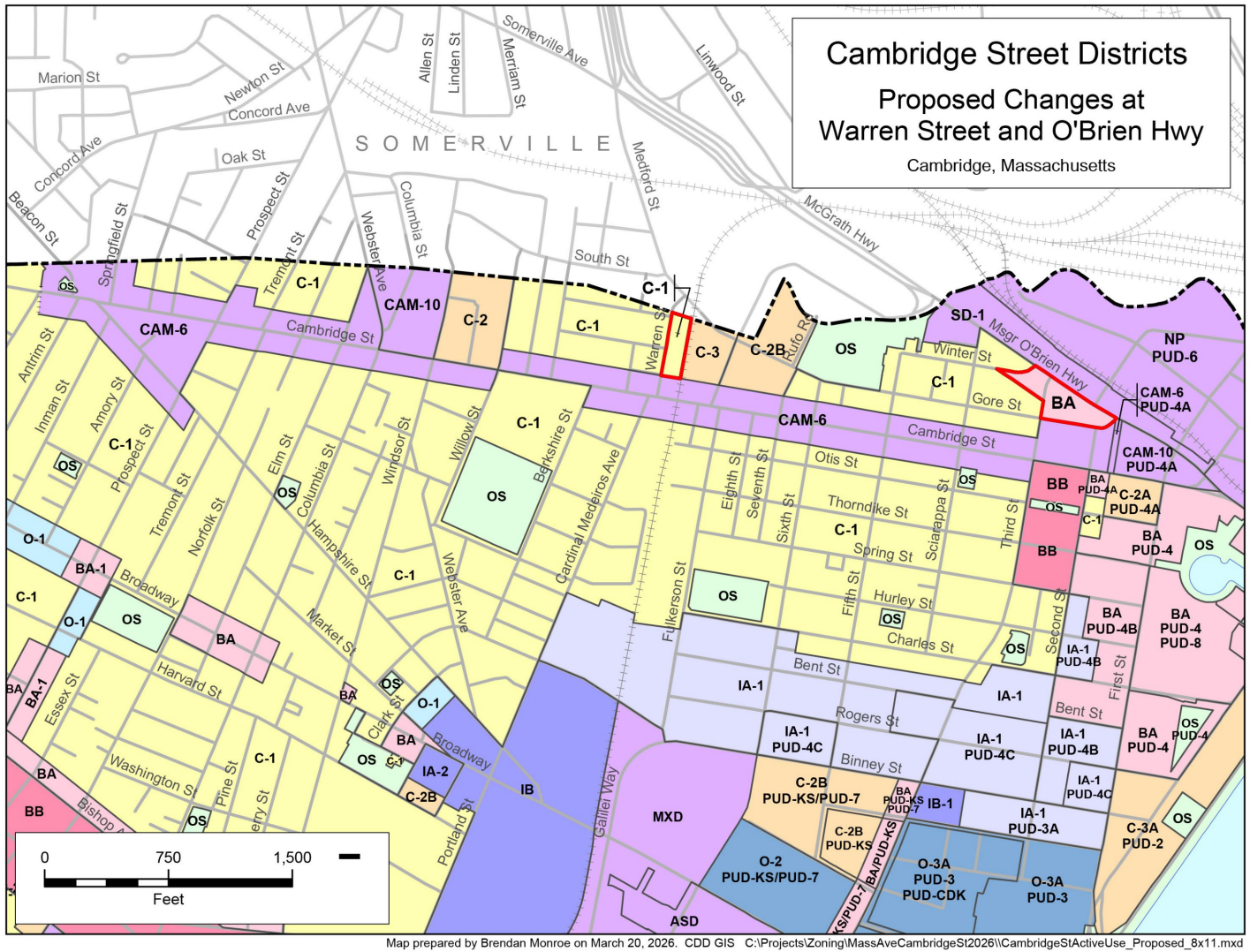
- Active uses required above 3 stories from **Inman to Windsor Street** and **Fifth Street to Lechmere**.
- Active uses required above 4 stories between Windsor Street and Fifth Street.



Cambridge Street Recommendations

General Recommendation:

- Rezone Warren Street and O'Brien Hwy edges where Active Uses are not a priority.



Considerations

Option 1

- Some 4-story residential without active use where 6-story mixed-use buildings are infeasible.
- **More housing, possibly less active use.**

Option 2

- Could be some 3-story residential where 6-story mixed buildings are infeasible, but redevelopment is less likely altogether.
- **Less housing, possibly more existing active use space is preserved but not guaranteed.**

Option 3

- Stronger active use requirements in nodes could help prioritize business activity in those areas.
- **More detailed approach may add complexity without much additional benefit.**